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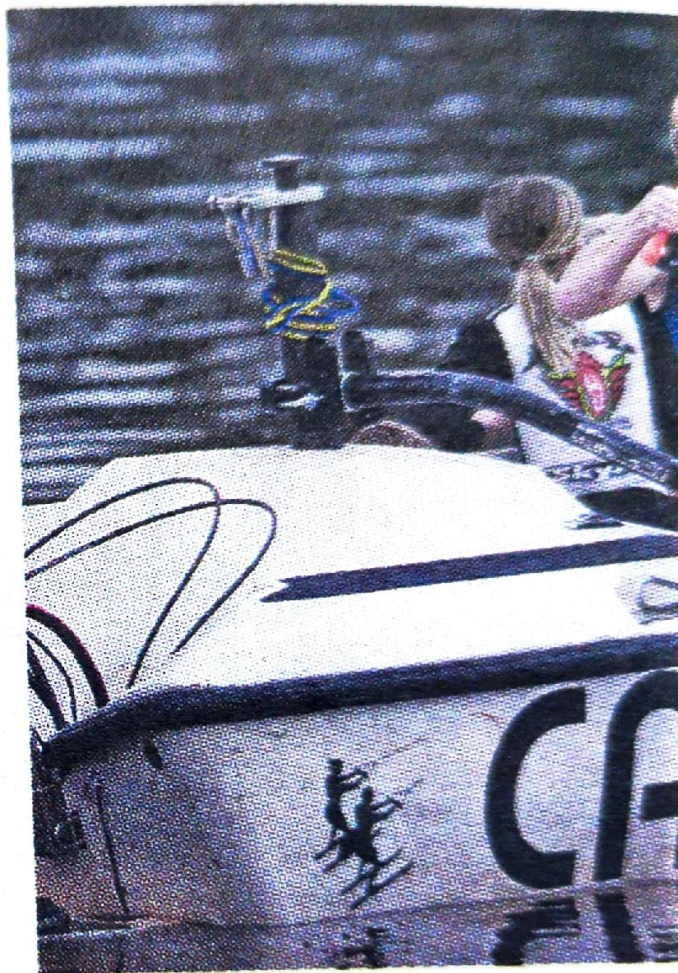


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An elevation drawing shows what the new Quest Adventure Center at the Latta Plantation Nature Preserve will look like.

Courtesy of Robert Touchstone

Raptor Center quest campaign launches

by LACEY HAMPTON
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HUNTERSVILLE – The public funding campaign for the Carolina Raptor Center's Quest Adventure Center has started.

The \$11.6 million campaign will assist with the creation of the Quest Adventure Center, which the Raptor Center has partnered with Mecklenburg County Park and Recreation to create at the Latta Plantation Nature Preserve.

The facility will feature a state-of-the-art environmental education center, new raptor trail system, resident bird care facility and exhibit, aviaries and more, according to a Carolina Raptor Center news release.

"The county initiated the project," Michele Miller Houck, associate executive director of the Carolina Raptor Center, said.

About 10 years ago, bonds were passed for it, but the recession hit, and instead, the release of the bonds was postponed. A couple of years ago the county came back to them about the project, and since then the center has been working with the county toward making it a reality. The county is now working to get construction drawings

for the project done. As of now there are just elevation drawings for it, Miller said.

"We'll probably break ground sometime in early to late summer (2017), and it will probably take a year to 18 months to build," she said.

With the creation of the Quest Adventure Center, the Carolina Raptor Center will have access to a larger classroom and multipurpose space, which it can use for its different programs. The existing Carolina Raptor Center is planned to be renovated to become a state-of-the-art hospital for wild birds, as the property already houses a raptor treatment facility that may be the largest of its kind in the United States, according to its website.

To date the Raptor Center has secured \$8.8 million of the \$11.6 million needed for the project, which includes \$1.8 million in private resources that adds to the approximate \$7 million capital project by Mecklenburg County Park and Recreation for the facility.

Additional information about the new facility and how to donate to the campaign visit www.carolinaraptorcenter.org/support/quest-campaign/. □

LAKE NORMAN